Such stories are to be heard whenever real estate crops up as a subject for discussion. I have more than a few to tell about my own family—and about myself.

In the 1880s, the city of Detroit, Michigan, had a population of about 116,000. My mother's brother-in-law, Travers Leach, owned a 160-acre farm outside what were then Detroit's city limits. Sometime before the turn of the century, Leach sold the farm for a few thousand dollars, making what he considered a fair profit on the sale.

Unfortunately, Travers Leach could not foresee that by 1920 the population of Detroit would soar to nearly 1,000,000 and that a mushrooming urban area would engulf his farmland. Had he held onto his farm, he and his heirs would have become multimillionaires. By 1920, each of his 160 acres was worth many, many times what the

entire property had been worth in the 1890s. Today, of course, a 160-acre tract in what has become virtually the heart of Detroit would fetch an astronomical sum.

In 1906, my father could have purchased all of 70-square-mile Santa Catalina Island off the Southern California coast for only $250,000. He turned the offer down. Catalina Island was later purchased by the Wrigley interests and transformed into one of the best-known and most profitable resort areas on the West Coast. For years, the value of Santa Catalina Island has been calculated in the tens of millions of dollars.

During the Depression years, I could have picked up huge parcels of undeveloped land in Southern California and elsewhere for only a few dollars per acre. In those days, the tracts were far outside the limits of any incorporated town or city. Since 1945, the towns and cities have grown with lightning speed, spreading out in all directions. The once practically worthless tracts have become thriving residential or industrial areas. Much land that sold for as little as $500 an acre—and even less—in the Depression days now brings $50,000 and even more per acre.